FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Let us begin with science because science is not in dispute. An egg is the most complete, the cleanest, the most reliable, the most bio-available form of protein, the easiest and the most cost-effective to deliver to a growing child. Why does a fact that has long been proven come up repeatedly for debate? Because, in India, culture and politics interfere with the food choices available to everyone. And few foods reveal the fault lines as sharply as an egg on a school student's lunch plate. It came up most recently in the unlikeliest of places: West Bengal. Soon after the BJP formed a government here on May 9, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari handed over the contract for delivering cooked meals in around 1,800 schools in Kolkata to the religious organisation ISKCON, which has a strictly vegetarian code. That meant eggs would vanish from the plate. The outrage that followed has prompted a reversal. On July 29, Adhikari decreed that eggs would be supplied separately by self-help groups. But that this debate could even occur in Bengal, a state almost axiomatically non-vegetarian, raises questions. Why should a sect's dietary code determine what schoolchildren eat? Why is India's health and nutrition often subordinated to other considerations? Is vegetarianism being quietly made the default public culture through policy?



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It is perverse that such questions should arise in a country with the world's highest number of children afflicted by stunting and wasting, with rates comparable to Sub-Saharan Africa. The policy solution is blindingly simple: get all children into school, serve eggs to whoever will have it. But this is exactly where we see a sharp boundary drawn between states. PM POSHAN is the world's largest programme of its kind, providing hot, cooked meals to over 112 million children across a million schools. But states decide the menu, and presently 20 states and Union territories, including Bengal, serve eggs. That leaves 16 on the other side of The Great Egg Divide. Tamil Nadu, which pioneered the concept of mid-day meals, was the first to add eggs to the menu in 1989. Other southern states followed: Andhra Pradesh now serves eggs five days a week, Telangana thrice; many serve them twice. Match 'no egg' states against data for stunting and wasting, and one sees a tragic overlap in Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Maharashtra—the last having retracted after a brief, controversial rollout in 2023.

Stunting and wasting are tied to poor maternal health, but treating it as a separate problem is fallacious. Girls getting eggs in school would be at far less risk of growing up feeble. It is not a coincidence that Tamil Nadu and Kerala also have India's best maternal health indices. In Jharkhand, a past BJP regime introduced eggs as the first line of attack on future poverty. Payal Kumari, a 13-year-old in Ranchi, looks forward to Mondays and Fridays, the egg days. "They taste really good," she says. "At home, we can afford egg curry only on Sundays." Everywhere, teachers affirm eggs raise attendance.

That leaves culture. The stereotype of India as a 'vegetarian country' fares rather poorly against reality. India is overwhelmingly non-vegetarian—official data says about 80 per cent. This has historically included Brahmins in at least 14 states. Vegetarianism is concentrated heavily in a northwestern arc running from Gujarat to Punjab. A social contract binds the scenario: both cultures coexist. No one imposes a meat diet on vegetarians. The converse should be true too: a plant-based diet can perfectly be the preferred cultural or ethical choice for anyone. What it cannot be is public policy. The State must be diet-neutral. Food equity and food democracy require nothing less.

Our cover story this week, with Senior Editor Sonali Acharjee anchoring state inputs, spans the gamut: from health to culture to the evolution of policy. It is impossible to beat eggs as a dietary item in India's mid-day meals on a host of parameters. Each egg is a full carton of high-quality protein, ticking all nine essential amino acids and other key nutrients, in a form a child's body absorbs near perfectly, better than meat, fish and soy, with *dal* far behind. Only milk matches it, which is why dairy-heavy 'vegetarian' states like Punjab and Haryana largely escape the stunting/wasting curse. But, unlike egg, milk needs a vast cold chain back-up. At Rs 7-8, egg also costs half of what paneer does for a like amount of protein. With near-zero chances of tampering. A simple expedient to cut stunting risk by nearly half and promote cognitive growth. To walk away from such extraordinary value on cultural grounds that are not shared is folly. Turning India's demographic dividend into a healthy, mentally sharp workforce for the future is a common need. The wise, ethical and practical course for policy is to enable, not hinder choice.

Get the best vegetarian for those who don't eat eggs. But don't universalise one community's taboo. Such public policy deprives millions of children of the nutrition they need to think clearly, grow properly and contribute to India's future. Let every child who eats an egg have one on the plate. Science says so. All that's hindering it is a political choice masquerading as a cultural one.



(Aroon Purie)